

The Little Book of Jonah

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St. Elizabeth's Anglican Mission

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Table of Contents

Preface.....	4
Introducing Jonah.....	5
Jonah Flees.....	9
The Storm.....	10
Psalm of Jonah.....	13
On to Nineveh.....	17
Worst Prophet Ever.....	19
Walking Through Nineveh.....	22
Jonah's Anger.....	26
The Curtain Drops.....	30
Final Words.....	31

Dedicated to the saints of St. Elizabeth's
Anglican Mission, both near and far.

Preface

Hi! Thanks for taking some time to read this little book. It started out as a series of letters to the members of St. Elizabeth's Anglican Mission (near Pittsburgh) during the time of COVID-19 lock down. StEAM (to the best of my knowledge) is the first church planted inside of a retirement community — average about 85; as such during the early weeks of the COVID-19 lock down, we could not meet. Most of my folks are not technologically adapt, nor does StEAM have the facilities to stream service, so I began writing letters. What you have here is six weeks of letter edited into more or less book form.

I was reading through my old stuff and came upon these letter and I thought, “Hey! This is pretty good.” So, here it is for you. I hope you enjoy it.

Grace and peace

The Rev. Paul A. Sutcliffe, Jr

Introducing Jonah

We started off into a short Bible Study on the Book of Jonah. The one thing everyone knows about Jonah is he spent 3 days in the belly of a large fish. I find it a curiosity when one person says, “the belly of a whale” there is sure to be someone who will say, “a whale isn’t a fish.” I think it is safe to say the distinction between fish and whale was not something the writer of Jonah cared very much about, just as modern readers and writers — of a non-technical sort — consider anything living in the sea and swimming about to be a fish.

While being swallowed by a fish and surviving for 3 days is memorable, it is not what the Book of Jonah is about. The fish incident only serves to move the story forward. I will save you the trouble of reading all the way to the end and tell you the Book of Jonah is about the mercy of God and what can be our pathetic response to it. It is written as hope and a warning.

The Book of Jonah is included in the books of the prophets of the Old Testament, but there is only one sentence of prophecy included in the four chapters of Jonah, and that one sentence is the single worst prophetic statement in the

entire Bible. It's so bad; in fact, I don't think The Book of Jonah should be considered a book of prophecy at all. If not a book of prophecy then what sort of book is the Book of Jonah? Here, I will warn you that I hold a distinctly minority view on this topic. Let the reader beware!

I consider the Book of Jonah to be a melodrama of two or three acts, with an interlude between the first and second acts. The chief characteristic of a melodrama is that everything is pictured in stark contrast—the good guys are the best of all possible good guys, the bad guys are the worst of all possible bad guys, and the situations are always the worst of all possible circumstances.

A prophet by the name of Jonah is mentioned in 2 Kings 14:25, but gives us no other information other than he was a prophet in the northern kingdom of Israel and lived about 850-ish years before Christ. Being a prophet of the Northern Kingdom is not something most people would want on their resumes, but we are told nothing good or bad about him there.

In the first four verses of chapter one, we are told the word of the Lord came to Jonah to go and speak out against the city of Nineveh because its evil had come before the Lord. Recall that the evil of Sodom and Gomorrah also came before

the Lord, and He destroyed them. This was bad news for Nineveh.

During the time of Jonah, Nineveh was most likely the largest city in the world — Pittsburgh-ish sized by modern standards — and was the capital of the Assyrian Empire. The Assyrians were the ones who overran the northern kingdom of Israel and scattered the residents far and wide throughout the Assyrian empire. Not nice people.

Jonah is given the task of declaring to Nineveh that the Lord will destroy them because of their evil. In response to this call, Jonah rose up to flee the presence of the Lord. He went down to Joppa on the Mediterranean coast, found a ship heading for Tarshish, and went on board as a passenger.

Geography is our friend here. It helps to know that Nineveh was far off to the East (in northern Iraq, near modern-day Mosul, on the Tigris River) — for this story, Nineveh is the Eastern End of the World. Tarshish, on the other hand, was the Western End of the World, think Gibraltar, southern Spain, where the Mediterranean Sea meets the Atlantic Ocean. Keep going West, and there is nothing but open ocean until you get to the Americas — but they didn't know that then. The picture we have is the Lord telling Jonah to go as far East as he can and preach against

Nineveh. Jonah tries to go as far West as he can to escape doing what the Lord wanted him to do.

Truth is, not many people respond positively when the Lord asks them to do something, most notably Moses. Though he never says no, he does put up a prolonged argument with the Lord, outlining every reason why the Lord has picked the wrong person. Jonah, on the other hand, does not argue; he flees. In the time of Jonah, gods were thought to be localized — they worked within their prescribed boundaries, and Jonah acts like this is what he believes even though sometime later he speaks otherwise. The Book of Jonah bears witness to the Lord being the God of everything and everywhere.

The picture being built up is of a prophet who definitely refuses to do what the Lord wants him to do. Not a very good prophet. When I have heard others talk about Jonah (in fairness — it is not often) I hear them talk about Jonah's faithfulness, about his dependence on the Lord to save him when he volunteers to be thrown into the sea to save the ship. This is often how he is presented in Children's Bible Stories. We will find this understanding is not supported by the text.

Jonah Flees

In Jonah's attempt to flee from the Lord, we read that Jonah goes to the seaport of Joppa, pays his fare, and goes down into the ship bound for Tarshish. There are a couple of curious things here. The first is that Jonah "pays his fare." Back in the bad 'ol days of Jonah, money was a fairly recent innovation. Prior to money, the medium of exchange was obligation, obligation to individuals, and to the community where you lived. Remember the scene from The Godfather where the undertaker asks a favor of the Godfather. Money is not exchanged, but obligation is created. Money is a means to avoid obligation.

The other curious thing here is that most people "go on board" a ship, but Jonah "goes down into the ship." Picture this as opera. The stage is set with all the sailors preparing to set sail and the main character is not on stage. What we have so far is a prophet who has abandoned his duties, abandoned his people, and, lastly, abandoned all human contact in an effort to flee from what the Lord would have him do. Jonah flees everyone and his obligation to ship and crew.

As it turns out, and we will see, Jonah is the kind of believer in the Lord who is only interested in the Lord when it suits

him and his personal desires, driven by the question, “What’s in it for me?”

The Storm

With Jonah deep in the ship, she heads out for Tarshish. In Jonah’s day, Tarshish was known for gold, silver, tin, and iron. If you were on your way to Tarshish, you took a big ship to return a heavy cargo. It is reasonable to think of Jonah’s ship as being as large as they made them back then. When the Lord sends the storm, it is large enough to threaten this large ship.

As the ship threatens to break up, the sailors, being the religious and superstitious lot they are, all begin crying out to their own god in the hope that some god would come to their rescue. It was all hands on deck, everyone doing everything they could think of to save the ship.

Except Jonah. You should know that, at sea, in an emergency, everyone is part of the crew. This was especially true in the days of sail, where if all you could do was haul on a line, that’s what you did. Jonah did not; he continued to sleep below deck.

We read the captain finds Jonah asleep and says to him, “What do you mean, you sleeper?” I imagine if this had been written in an age when “proper” language was the exception rather than the rule (like our age), the captain would probably have

used saltier language. Perhaps this is a moment of humor in this melodrama, the captain saying something like, “You... , you..., you sleeper!” with the audience expecting something else. Laughter ensues.

The scene is set. Why isn’t Jonah praying to his god? We learn a lot about Jonah in the next few moments. The ship is threatening to break up, killing all hands, and Jonah is not praying. This is how much he does not want to go to Nineveh. He would rather die, taking all hands with him. Here, we learn Jonah, knowing the Lord, is without pity. Jonah without pity is central to understanding the book.

The sailors, in full recognition, that this catastrophe is out of their control, cast lots to discover who on board is responsible. They needn’t have bothered because pitiless Jonah knows full well what is going on. The lot falls on him, and he finally confesses he is a Hebrew who fears the Lord, the God of heaven who made the sea and dry land, and tells them the whole story. The sailors respond, “What have you done (are you mad)?” I imagine other sailor-like expletives were deleted. In fear, they ask, “What shall we do?”

Pitiless Jonah responds, “Throw me into the sea!” as he would rather die than go to Nineveh. Take a moment to realize Jonah could have said, “Take me to Nineveh,”

but death is the preferable option. The sailors knew throwing Jonah overboard would be wrong, had pity on him, dug in, and rowed hard for dry land. But to no avail.

In desperation, the sailors plead with the Lord—take note again, they are not praying to their various gods but now pray as one to the Lord. They plead not to be held accountable for Jonah's life, confessing the Lord had done exactly what the Lord wanted to do. They hurl Jonah into the sea.

This is not the end of the sailors. As the sea calmed, "... the men feared the Lord exceedingly, and they offered a sacrifice to the Lord and made vows." The sailors abandon their gods and come to believe in the Lord making promises to Him, not because of what Jonah said, but because of what the Lord did.

We are not quite done with Jonah in this act, either. Jonah gets his wish: He is thrown into the sea, thinking death is at hand, and the Lord will have to find someone else to go to Nineveh. As always, the Lord's plans are not so easily thwarted. He still cares for Jonah and will have no other prophet for Nineveh. The Lord provides a large fish to save Jonah, giving him transportation back to land.

What can we take away? Most obviously, the Lord's plans will not be thwarted. It is a fool's errand to work in opposition to the God of Heaven and Earth. Not so obvious, in spite of Jonah's rebellion, the Lord still cares for him and provides for him. Lastly, as far as our melodrama goes, we learn Jonah is not the hero of the story - he is the anti-hero - he is the villain. Surprise!

Psalm of Jonah

I dread writing about the second chapter of Jonah. I have spent many hours struggling to understand its place in the story of Jonah but to no avail. The Jonah found in the second chapter seems to be vastly different from the Jonah found in chapters 1, 3, & 4. The Jonah of chapter 2 appears to be a faithful servant of the Lord. The other Jonah seems to be a rebellious twit.

When I turn to the Book of Jonah, my initial reaction is to say, "How about we just skip Chapter 2?" Indeed some biblical scholars have suggested Chapter 2 was not part of the original story. One can read Chapters 1, 3, & 4, skipping over Chapter 2, and it teaches the same lesson. Others, including myself, have suggested Chapter 2 belongs at the end of the book. It would make more sense overall if Jonah's psalm were the conclusion.

I see two problems with these suggestions of relocating or removing Jonah's Psalm. The first problem is this: The text we have, in the order we have it, is the text that has been given us. And if we believe the Lord has given us the Bible he intends us to have - which I do - then the reader of Jonah (aka, me) has to deal with Chapter 2 just as it is, where it is.

The second problem with relocating or removing Chapter 2 is all it serves to do is make reading the Book of Jonah easier for the modern reader. Here is a general principle in Bible reading: If the text is difficult for me to make sense of, that's my problem and not the problem of the original author or original audience. It made perfect sense to them. In other words, laziness on my part is not a valid technique for understanding Scripture.

Jonah prays his psalm from the belly of the fish. It must have been dark, wet, cold, and smelled bad. I imagine being wrapped in a half a ton of smoked salmon. The first thing to notice is, Jonah prays his psalm in the past tense! He prays as if his prayer has already been answered. In the midst of his trouble, he prays as if the Lord has already listened to him and answered him.

I rebel against Jonah being any sort of positive role model because he is such a miserable character. Even so, praying as if his prayers have already been answered is

a very good way to pray. Let that sink in a moment: Pray as if your prayers are already answered,

One of the frustrating, peculiar, annoying - take your pick - thing about prayer is you, personally, might not see the results of your prayers. To be clear, you might see the results, but you might not. But then, who gets to see the results of your prayers is a home office issue and not up to us. Our responsibility is to pray. Jonah's psalm is a good one to pray when you are at the end of your rope. Jonah certainly had no rope to spare being in the belly of a fish, in the belly of the deep.

The psalm itself is flawless in its style and theology. Had it been included in The Book of Psalms it would not have been out of place. In short, it acknowledges the Lord to be the God of All, heaven and earth, and beneath the earth, a God who is ever present regardless of our location and circumstance. Jonah acknowledges there is no better place to be than in the presence of the Lord and no better thing to do than to keep your vows to the Lord.

Therein lies Jonah's subtle flaw. I confess to you finding this flaw did not come easy; I have not found mention of it in my readings, so giving credit where credit is due, I give thanks to the Lord for opening my eyes to it. At the end of Jonah's psalm, he declares, "I will pay that which I have

vowed. Salvation belongs to Yahweh.” The work of figuring out what is not said belongs to the reader. What Jonah does not say is, “And I never vowed to go to Nineveh, so you can just forget about it!” Jonah is not faithless; he has a deep (literally, deep in the ocean) and abiding faith. He turns to the Lord in his darkest moment and believes in the Lord’s salvation. All that is true about Jonah, but Jonah is disobedient.

Here lies an important lesson: It is possible to be a person of great faith and still be disobedient. I am tempted to bring out a long list of examples of faithful believers who were disobedient, beginning with Adam (I stretch the point a bit with Adam in that he didn’t believe in the Lord; he knew the Lord, even so, he was still disobedient). As I reflect on other examples, it occurs to me that everyone, to a greater or lesser degree, is disobedient, especially when it comes to the Lord.

With respect to Jonah, what we see is a person in the midst of his “in your face” disobedience still expecting the Lord to be merciful to him! There is no hint of, “Hmm, maybe I should have gone to Nineveh.” Not even, “If I ever get out of this alive, I’ll go to Nineveh.” Jonah’s disobedience is as important to him as his faith - possibly more so! Here is a question for us: What are those things we

would do before we would be obedient to the Lord?

The deeper question the Book of Jonah asks is this: What do we ask for ourselves from the Lord that we would have Him deny others? Having tried and failed to escape the Lord's reach, Jonah asks for the Lord's mercy. What we are going to see is Jonah's desire for the Lord's Mercy to be withheld from others. In this way, Jonah's Psalm is a perfect introduction to the last two chapters. In the meantime, we are reminded of the importance of obedience to the Lord and the recognition of the part we play in the actions of the Lord.

On to Nineveh

We left off with the same old selfish Jonah praying his psalm in the belly of the fish. When Jonah completed his psalm, we are told the Lord spoke to the fish and it vomited Jonah out onto the dry land. Thus far, we have four "characters" in the book: the Lord, Jonah, the sailors, and the fish. Between Jonah, the sailors, and the fish, only Jonah is disobedient to the Lord. The fish is just a fish; the Lord only needed to speak to the fish for it to be obedient. The sailors had multiple gods, abandoning them to be faithful to the Lord. Jonah, who is a prophet of the Lord, is the only one who actively tries to not do what the

Lord asks of him. A question to keep in mind through the end of the book: Is Jonah obedient?

Having been vomited up onto dry land, it is not difficult to imagine Jonah on the beach covered in fish vomit. Disgusting — in spite of the fact that Jonah is fish vomit. Jonah taking some time to clean up is also not difficult to imagine. What is difficult to imagine is Jonah needing to be told again to go to Nineveh. And yet, the word of the Lord has to come to Jonah a second time in order to actually get him to go to Nineveh. I would think a storm at sea and a three-day ride in a fish stomach would be enough, but in Jonah's case, he must be told again.

From the coast of Israel to Nineveh is in the neighborhood of 750 miles, comparable to the distance from New York City to Chicago. We are not told about Jonah's travel to Nineveh, but if he were going to walk — probably — it would take him 20 to 30 days. It is mostly desert, with oases along the way (it is interesting to use Google Maps to get an idea of the terrain. Google Maps, says it would take 227 hours to walk from Haifa to Mosul, aka Joppa to Nineveh).

We are told Nineveh was a great city, and it took 3 days just to walk through it. At the very end of the book, the population of Nineveh is set at greater than 120,000 men

(not counting women and children). In its day, Nineveh was the largest city in the world. I imagine not unlike modern-day Pittsburgh (but then, that's where I live). Population aside, we're talking about an area about 60 miles in diameter (not quite 2900 square miles). The size of Nineveh is important because of what comes next

Jonah walks one day's distance into the city (about 20 miles) and says one time, "Within 40 days Nineveh will be overturned." Most English translations say "destroyed," but it is equally valid to say "overturned." In the context of what eventually happens in Nineveh, "overturned" makes more sense. Even so, in the context of what the inhabitants of Nineveh understood Jonah to say, "destroyed" would make more sense. The ambiguity might (and that's a big maybe) make Jonah's word from the Lord mean, "If you don't change your ways, Nineveh will be destroyed." One way or another, Nineveh would change.

Worst Prophet Ever

There are several peculiar things about Jonah's prophecy to Nineveh. The first is that the text implies Jonah declared his prophecy one time. That is weird. Prophecies, words from the Lord, are meant to be repeated. Jonah does not

repeat what he has been told to say; he says it only once. The second oddity is that Jonah still has ten miles to go before he reaches the city center. In other words, when he makes his one prophetic statement, he is still in suburban Nineveh!

The third, perhaps most important peculiarity is what is not said. Biblical prophets always assert in their prophecies, "Thus saith the Lord." It is a way of saying, "This is not my opinion, this comes from the Lord." Jonah fails to declare the origin of his prophecy. For all the residents of Nineveh knew, some foreigner said something bad would happen to Nineveh within the next 40 days. I have heard enough goofballs in my lifetime proclaiming the end of all things to ignore them all. I imagine the residents of Nineveh behaved likewise.

Perhaps the most peculiar thing about Jonah's prophecy is the people of Nineveh believed him. Whoever heard Jonah repeated what Jonah said. The prophecy even outruns Jonah! Before Jonah is able to finish his walk through the city, everyone from the king on down has heard the word from the Lord and repented! This would make Jonah the most successful prophet of all time! Oddly, it is not Jonah who spreads the word; it is the pagan Ninevites!

“Successful” has never been a part of a prophet’s job description, while “faithful” is always at the top of the list. Jonah’s success is completely out of the ordinary — particularly considering his lack of faithfulness. Here is a lesson: Success before our Lord is not determined by any measurement we might devise — including faithfulness! The best we can do is try to be faithful, for “... God knows your hearts. For what is exalted among men is an abomination in the sight of God.” (Luke 16:15)

Here is another unusual thing: The king of Nineveh hears the prophecy and believes. He does not hear it from Jonah but from his own people. Believing is one thing, acting on that belief is something else again. The King of Nineveh believes, declares a fast by all people and animals, steps down from his throne, and personally repents in sackcloth and ashes (for the reader: make a list of leaders throughout history who did what he expected his people to do. A 3x5 card should be sufficient. You may use the rest of the card for your grocery list).

Note also the similarity between the King of Nineveh and Jesus, in that both give up the trappings of their office to lead the people. The king abandons his throne to lead his people in repentance; Jesus abandons his god-ness to lead his people.

All of this repenting before the Lord happens before Jonah leaves Nineveh. He sees what repentance looks like in Nineveh. Jonah is not pleased.

Walking Through Nineveh

Up to this point, Jonah has walked a third of the way into the city of Nineveh, repeated the word of the Lord — neglecting to mention it was from the Lord — and continued to walk through the city. By the time Jonah has finished walking through Nineveh, the entire city, from the king on down to the herds and flocks, are wearing sackcloth and repenting from their evil deeds in the hope God (and they are not exactly sure which god) will change his mind about destroying Nineveh. Thoughts of Sodom and Gomorrah must surely be on their minds. Most likely, the fate of Sodom and Gomorrah was part of the world's spoken history at the time.

When God saw what they did, how they turned from their evil way, God relented from the disaster that he had said he would do to them, and he did not do it. But it displeased Jonah exceedingly, and he was angry. (Jonah 3:10, 4:1)

Was Jonah angry? How often is it that people take to heart the things the Lord says to them and change their ways?

Those of us who are preachers, in our sermons, do have a tendency to include the theme, “Quit Sinning!” I think we do this out of a sense of obligation rather than any expectation people will actually quit sinning. In about 1000 sermons I’ve preached now, I can remember one time someone saying to me, “Boy, you were right. I’m going to quit doing that”. I suspect I have a better percentage than most preachers. But Jonah is an unqualified success as a preacher/prophet based on the outcome (even if not by his presentation). And yet, Jonah is still angry.

What are we to make of Jonah’s reaction? What we can conclude at this point is Jonah had always hoped that Nineveh would be destroyed. At the time of Jonah, Nineveh was the capital city of Assyria. The king of Assyria, Sargon II (king from about 721 to 705 BC), invaded, destroyed, and annexed the Northern Kingdom of Israel. Assyrian inscriptions say close to thirty thousand inhabitants were led away as booty. Apparently, when the Assyrians led people into captivity, they pulled them along with fish hooks through their jaws. Grizzly action. Small wonder why Jonah would like to see Nineveh destroyed. I can imagine living in that era, and if I’d heard Nineveh had been destroyed, I would have said, “Well, it’s about time!”

Here's a question: Did the Lord want Nineveh to be destroyed? In the first chapter, we read the Lord saying, "Arise, go to Nineveh, that great city, and call out against it, for their evil has come up before me." Compare that with what the Lord says about Sodom and Gomorrah: "Then the Lord said, "Because the outcry against Sodom and Gomorrah is great and their sin is very grave, I will go down to see whether they have done altogether according to the outcry that has come to me. And if not, I will know." (Gen 18.20-21) We know what happened there! If you didn't know the story, it would be easy to think the days of Nineveh were numbered. Forty days from Jonah's arrival, to be exact.

And yet, we learn the Lord decides not to destroy Nineveh because they repent of their evil ways. It sort of sounds like the Lord is interested in repentance. Well, sure, but repentance is only the first step in living a life of repentance. It is as if the Lord is saying, "Look, this can't go on and I am not going to let it go on." The response of Nineveh to the Lord's word to them is a lot more than, "Yeah, yeah, we won't do that evil stuff any more." It was a beginning. The Lord took them at their word (and actions) and relented.

I am reminded of John 3:17, "For God did not send his Son into the world to

condemn the world, but in order that the world might be saved through him.”

Oddly, people seem to like disasters — not actually being in them but watching from afar. Note the popularity of disaster movies and how drivers slow down to get a good look at a traffic accident. When it comes to our enemies — or even people who annoy us — we mostly prefer our enemies experience disaster. Certainly, destruction is what Jonah wanted for Nineveh, whether or not it is what the Lord wanted.

You will note that when we pray the Lord’s Prayer, we say, “Thy will be done on earth as it is in heaven.” We do not add, “... as long as it is consistent with my will.” Jonah, even though a prophet, conversant with the Lord, is an extreme example. Not only did Jonah not want the Lord’s will done, he actively tried to thwart it. When the Lord chose not to take Jonah’s feelings about Nineveh into consideration, Jonah was angry. Jonah was so angry he desired not to live in a world where the Lord’s will was done.

The lesson for us here comes in the form of a question: Would we rather live in a world where the Lord’s will is done or not? The answer to this question may seem self-evident. Even so, when you ponder the question seriously you are probably able to come up with something.

I had a parishioner say to me once, “If Hitler is in heaven, I don’t want to be there.” Jonah lives in our hearts today.

We are to take seriously, very seriously, what the Lord wants. What he wants is the elimination of evil — personal and corporate. If you want to know what the Lord wants, consider the Good Samaritan. Consider also how the Lord wants us to care for and about our enemies (which includes the people who annoy you if you think you have no enemies)

Jonah’s Anger

We are near the end of the Book of Jonah. Jonah has walked through Nineveh, West to East, and having witnessed the repentance of the Ninevites, he continues East as he grows angry with the Lord. In an outburst, he accuses the Lord, “O Lord, is not this what I said when I was yet in my country? That is why I made haste to flee to Tarshish; for I knew that you are a gracious God and merciful, slow to anger and abounding in steadfast love, and relenting from disaster.”

I have noticed it is part of the human condition to blame bad things that happen on the Lord — or at least question His wisdom in allowing bad things to happen. There is little asking of what we could have done differently or do differently in

the future. This behavior comes naturally. I suppose, in some way, it helps us make sense of the nonsensical. I am completely flummoxed by Jonah's angry outburst — he is not angry because the Lord did something or allowed something horrible to happen. Jonah is angry because the Lord showed mercy!?! I am so taken aback I want to grab Jonah by the shoulders and shout into his face, "What the <insert rude word> is WRONG with you!"

But I think I may have missed the joke. The next thing Jonah says is, "O Lord, please take my life from me, for it is better for me to die than to live." Still don't see the joke? Admittedly, it is not a knee-slapper, so allow me to paraphrase... Jonah says, "This whole thing is YOUR fault. I knew you'd have mercy on my avowed enemies! Therefore, have mercy on ME, kill me so I don't have to live in a world where you are merciful to others." I confess I would be back to my rude response offered above, but the Lord says, "Do you do well to be angry?" I cannot be certain, but I think it is the Lord's way of saying, "Stop a minute and think about what you are saying."

Jonah offers no response and continues East. I suppose the Book of Jonah could have ended right here. The point's been made — the Lord is merciful — even to

people we think deserve His wrath rather than His mercy. But, of course, there is more to the story

Jonah gets to a safe distance from the city in case the Lord changes His mind and destroys Nineveh. Finding a convenient spot, Jonah builds a booth, a small hut, to get out of the sun and watch the hoped-for destruction of Nineveh. Apparently, building a booth is easier than lugging a tent around with you. Made from sticks, it allows for some cross-ventilation and some shade. The booth provides better shade if you can find some greenery for the roof, but if you are in a Middle Eastern desert, you manage with what you can find.

Jonah begins his watch over Nineveh. Thus far in the story, the only thing Jonah cares about is the destruction of Nineveh — a prophet without pity. In the night, as Jonah sleeps, the Lord appoints a plant to grow up over Jonah's booth to provide more shade and comfort. Jonah awakes to find he is now staying at the Park Plaza of booths — covered as it is with greenery, providing more shade and soft green lighting. We are told Jonah is “exceedingly glad” because of the plant. Take note in passing; we are not told that Jonah gives thanks to the Lord for the plant. Take note also that Jonah is now comfortable while he waits for destruction

to come upon Nineveh; all the while the citizens (including the flocks and herds) are repenting in dust and ashes. We should appreciate the irony.

While Jonah enjoys a comfortable day watching Nineveh suffer (and hoping for more), other plans are afoot! Tuckered out as Jonah is from a comfortable day of watching others suffer, he falls asleep. The Lord, who never sleeps, now appoints a worm to attack the shade plant that comforted Jonah. When the sun rises, Jonah finds the plant dead, no longer able to comfort him. Add to that a scorching East wind (appointed by the Lord), and Jonah must be as miserable as when he was in the belly of the fish — the difference being hot and dry vs. cold and wet (more irony, in case you missed it).

Jonah, now in misery, declares, “It is better for me to die than to live.” This is, apparently, Jonah’s “go to” response for situations he doesn’t like. The Lord asks him, “Are you angry because the plant died?” Jonah responds, “Yes, I am angry because of the plant! Angry enough to die!”

Slipping into paraphrasing of what the Lord says, “You, Jonah, would have the plant live and allow the people and cattle of Nineveh to die? You have nothing invested in the plant. You didn’t plant it or care for it (you cared only that it gave you

comfort). You have the capability of pity within you, but are only concerned with your own welfare. Nineveh, on the other hand — who knows nothing of me — at my word — delivered (sort of) by you — repented of what? They might not even know! Shouldn't I have pity on them?"

THE END

The Curtain Drops

In this melodrama, the curtain comes crashing down. You, dear audience, are left to stew over the kind of person you are. Are you more like Jonah, who loves only what comforts him? Or like the Lord, who will have mercy even on those who do not know him? Obviously a rhetorical question. We hope we grow to be more and more like the Lord and less and less like Jonah. To know the Lord is insufficient. To know the ways of the Lord is insufficient. To walk in the Lord's ways in the fear you might wander from His path — well, that is the beginning of Wisdom.

There is one last task to undertake regarding Jonah. What did Jesus have in mind when he told the Pharisees the only sign they would receive would be the sign of Jonah. Most think the sign is that Jonah spent three days in the belly of the fish,

and Jesus spent three days in the tomb.
There is more to it, and so...

Final Words

There is one last thing to say concerning Jonah: What did Jesus mean when he said,

For just as Jonah was three days and three nights in the belly of the great fish, so will the Son of Man be three days and three nights in the heart of the earth. The men of Nineveh will rise up at the judgment with this generation and condemn it, for they repented at the preaching of Jonah, and behold, something greater than Jonah is here. (Mt 12:40-41)

Jesus is shown to use the story of Jonah three times in the Gospels, twice in Matthew (chaps 12, 16) and once in Luke (chap 11). All three say about the same thing, but the Matthew 12 telling seems to be the most complete.

In Matthew 12 the scribes and Pharisees are looking for a sign from Jesus. The first part of Jesus' response is, "An evil and adulterous generation seeks for a sign, but no sign will be given to it except the sign of the prophet Jonah." It is easy to jump to the conclusion Jesus is referring to Jonah's three days in the belly of the fish as a sign of his own 3 days in the tomb following his crucifixion. Jesus says that right there.

Still, “three days and three nights in the belly of a great fish” doesn’t seem to fit with “An evil and adulterous generation seeks a sign,” even if it makes perfect sense looking back after the Resurrection. Also, Jesus doesn’t mention “the belly of the fish” in the other two instances where Jesus references Jonah. What does fit is, “The men of Nineveh will rise up at the judgment with this generation and condemn it.” This statement would have infuriated the scribes and Pharisees. It is also a perfect response to those seeking signs and wonders. How come?

Jesus describes his generation as both evil and adulterous — as many times as I have read this passage, when I walk away from it to work in the shop, or some such thing, what sticks in my head is not “adulterous” but “idolatrous.” Something inside of me doesn’t want Jesus to mean adultery. Let’s be clear about the meaning of adultery: it means being married to one person and, uh, being intimate with another. Jesus accuses his generation and in particular the scribes and the Pharisees, of being married to the Lord but loving something else. Jesus implies the scribes and Pharisees; indeed, his entire generation is married to the Lord but in love with a show. I will go so far as to say, in love with being entertained.

Those who are unfaithful with one are predisposed to be unfaithful with another — in for a penny, in for a pound. We are told by Luke, “The Pharisees, who were lovers of money, heard all these things, and they ridiculed [Jesus]”. (Luke 16:14) Jesus responds, “You are those who justify yourselves before men, but God knows your hearts. For what is exalted among men is an abomination in the sight of God.” (Luke 16:15) To be married to someone knowing their heart belongs to another is of the greatest sorrow. Jesus tells the Pharisees (and us), “You may look married to the Lord, but the Lord knows your heart belongs to another.”

It is an astonishing act of love that the Lord continues to love us when our hearts are so far removed from Him.

To this “evil and adulterous generation,” the only sign Jesus gives is the Sign of Jonah, warning the men of Nineveh will rise up at the judgment and condemn Jesus' generation because the Ninevites demanded nothing from Jonah, no sign; no wonder, they heard and believed and repented. No sign, no wonder, no show, no money — just a warning, told to them one time somewhere a half day's walk from the city center — and they believed and acted on what they heard.

The scribes and the Pharisees would not act on Jesus' word. They would not act

unless they could experience something they could not refute. The problem with signs and wonders, indeed any sort of show, is that you can always refute what you experience—it is the very nature of experience; it is always open to doubt.

To believe is to act. Anything else, at best, can only be described as an appreciation. I do not think the Lord has much time and space for those who say to Him, “I hear what you say and can appreciate it.” Ultimately, that phrase is nothing but a polite dismissal. The Lord will not be dismissed, but will persist, and insist on being heard.

We live in an age in which signs and wonders, and shows are all the rage. Around 100 AD, the Roman poet Julius introduced the phrase “bread and circuses” — food and entertainment — meaning if people’s bellies are full and they are entertained, matters of substance are forgotten. Bread and circuses are the food of death, milled from the lives of the poor. “What do you mean by crushing my people, by grinding the face of the poor?” declares the Lord God of hosts. (Isaiah 4:15).

The Ninevites heard the word of the Lord from Jonah, the word of life to them. They believed and acted on that belief. The scribes and the Pharisees heard the Word of the Lord — Jesus — and would not

believe, nor would they act. To this day, we perceive them to be bad actors in their faith. How much more are those who believe but do not act on their claim of faith, preferring bread and circuses — a booming economy and great shows — to the word of the Lord to act on behalf of the poor?

They are The Lord's people.